

Abdullah al-Khonaini

Contact Information

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PhD Candidate in Middle Eastern and Islamic Studies (IMEIS) at Durham University, UK, with research expertise in parliamentary committees, political economy, and citizenship in the Arabian Peninsula. Experienced in Participatory Action Research (PAR) and qualitative methodologies. Demonstrated teaching ability as a Graduate Teaching Assistant and a strong track record in civic engagement and policy advocacy. Recipient of the Franco-German Prize for Human Rights and the Rule of Law.

Education

- ❖ Ph.D. Candidate at the School of Government and International Affairs (SGIA), Durham University, Durham, UK – Expected September 2026
Thesis Title: *Rituals of Power: The Functions, Dynamics, and Transfigurations of the Parliamentary Committees of the Kuwaiti National Assembly, 1963 – 2024*
- ❖ M.A. in ‘Power, Participation, and Social Change’ at the Institute of Development Studies (IDS), Sussex University, Brighton, UK, 2018 – 2019, with Distinction
Thesis Title: *Critical Enquiry into the Marginalized Narratives of Expression: Reconstruction of Identity, Nationality, and Means of Participation in Kuwait*
- ❖ BSc in ‘Finance and Financial Institutions’ at the College of Business Administrative, Kuwait University, Kuwait City, 2004 – 2009

Research Interests

Society and political economy; political institutions and social change; parliamentary committees; power-relations; citizenship and belonging; participatory action research; West Asia and North Africa; Arabian Peninsula

Academic Publications

Book Chapters

- ❖ ‘Citizenship Revocation & Opposition Fragmentation in Kuwait after Arab Spring’ in *Breaking the Molds: Civil Society and Public Policymaking in the Arab World*, ed. Fatima Moussawi *et al.*, Issam Faris Institute for Public Policy and International Affairs (IFI), Dar Alfarabi: Beirut, 2025 (in Arabic; English available online)
- ❖ ‘Informal Advocacy: The Politics of Kuwait’s New Mental Health Law’, in *Breaking the Molds*, 2025 (in Arabic; English available online)
- ❖ ‘Re-examining Gender Norms in Kuwait: A Case Study of Article 198 of the Penal Code’, in *Breaking the Molds*, 2025 (in Arabic; English available online)
- ❖ ‘The City and Socio-Sustainability in the Gulf States: The Northern Project’ (in Arabic), in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020: Sustainability in the Gulf*, ed. Omar al-Shehabi, Hamad al-Rayes, Gulf Centre for Development Policies, Centre for Arab Unity Studies: Beirut, 2021
- ❖ ‘The Political Development in Kuwait: Summarising the Events of the Year 2019’ (in Arabic), in *The Enduring and the Evolving 2020: Sustainability in the Gulf*, 2021

Peer-Reviewed Articles

- ❖ ‘Transposing Citizenship: Acts of Belonging and Locality Among the Non-Citizen Population in the Arabian Peninsula’, in *Studies in Ethnicity and Nationalism (SEN)*, 2026
- ❖ ‘Spatial Patterns and Urban Governance in Kuwait: Exploring the Links Between the Physical, the Socio-Economic and the Political’, in *LSE Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series* (25), 2024, co-authored in consortium
- ❖ ‘Youth Citizenship Identities in Kuwait: The Role of Citizenship Education and the Kuwaiti Diwaniya’, in *LSE Middle East Centre Kuwait Programme Paper Series* (19), 2023, co-authored in consortium

Forthcoming Peer-Reviewed Articles

- ❖ ‘Built to Separate: Quantifying Migrant Residential Segregation Throughout Kuwait’s Urban Transformation, 1957-2021’, *TBD*, co-authored in consortium

Other Writings

Policy Writings

- ❖ ‘How Should the Biden Administration Support Human Rights & Democracy in the MENA? (Kuwait’s Case)’, in *Project on Middle East Democracy (POMED)*, Washington, D.C., 2021
- ❖ ‘How COVID-19 Stress-Tested the Relations between Residents & Citizens’, *Gulf International Forum (GIF)*, Washington, D.C., April 2020
- ❖ ‘Kuwait Debate Power over Citizenship’, *Arab Gulf States Institute (AGSI)*, Washington, D.C., 2017

Public Writings

- ❖ Whitepaper, ‘Bringing Out the Participatory Action Research (PAR) in Participants: Reflections and Lessons from *Aswatna* Programme: Educating for Inclusion’, *En.v*, Kuwait City, 2024, co-authored with Zainab Mirza
- ❖ Article, ‘Examining the KNA: How Did the Mayoral Legislation Originate?’ (in Arabic), *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021
- ❖ Article, ‘In Its Sixteenth Anniversary: Why Do Protesters Choose al-Erada Square?’ (in Arabic), *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021
- ❖ Article, ‘Understanding Kuwait’s Bureaucracy’ (in Arabic), *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021
- ❖ Article, ‘Explainer: How Do We Understand the Kuwaiti State Budget? (in Arabic), *Manshoor*, Kuwait City, 2021 co-authored with. Salman al-Naqi
- ❖ Article, ‘Kuwait Voted This Weekend. Who Won?’, *Washington Post, Good Authority* (formerly known as *The Monkey Cage*), Washington, D.C., 2020, co-authored with Dr. Daniel Tavana

Professional Affiliations, Academic Services, and Professional Positions

Teaching

- ❖ Graduate Teaching Assistant, Durham University, SGIA, Perspectives of Political Economy (SGIA1241), 2025/26

Professional Affiliations

- ❖ Graduate Student Representative (Non-Voting) Board Member, *Association for Gulf and Arabian Peninsula Studies (AGAPS)*, November 2025 – November 2026

Workshops and PAR Training

- ❖ Designer and Convener, Training of Trainers (ToT) for ‘Strengthening Migrant Rights Programme’ Participatory Action Research (PAR) Workshop, two-days, *En.v in partnership with International Labour Organisation (ILO)*, Kuwait City, 2024
- ❖ Designer and Convener, ToT for ‘Enbat: Nurturing Transformational Leadership’ PAR Workshop, five-days, *Kuwait Projects Company (KIPCO)*, Kuwait City, 2022
- ❖ Designer and Convener, a ToT for ‘Aswatna Programme: Educating for Inclusion’ PAR Programme, six-days, *En.v and Data4Change*, Kuwait City, 2021
- ❖ Facilitator, ‘Build: Collaborative Ideathon for Community in Crisis’ PAR Workshops, eight-days (virtual), *En.v in partnership with Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation (SDC) and Gray Area Collective*, Kuwait City, 2020
- ❖ Facilitator, ‘N-mu: Youth Engagement Programme’ PAR Workshops, five-days, *En.v in partnership with Eurasia Foundation and the International Research and Exchange Board*, Kuwait City, 2016

Previous Full-Time Positions

- ❖ Research Assistant, *Rai Institute for Research and Strategic Studies*, Kuwait City, 2014 – 2018
- ❖ Accountant, *Foreign Procurement Department, Ministry of Defence*, Kuwait City, 2011 – 2014

Previous Part-Time Positions

- ❖ Lead Researcher, ‘Gender Political Economy Analysis Research in Kuwait’, *Westminster Foundation for Democracy*, London, 2021 – 2022
- ❖ Lead Researcher, ‘Evaluation and Monitor Report of the Legal Unit Aid Programme by the Kuwait Trade Union Federation’, *International Labour Organisation (ILO)*, Kuwait City, 2022
- ❖ Editor, *Manshoor*, Kuwait, 2020 – 2021
- ❖ Researcher, ‘Restructuring the Kuwaiti Government’ Project, *Foundation for the Advancement of Science (KFAS) and Supreme Council for Planning and Development*, Kuwait City, 2021
- ❖ Research Assistant, ‘Neighbourhood Tales: Kuwait Under Lockdown’, Oral History Project, *En.v*, Kuwait City, 2020
- ❖ Research Assistant, ‘KFAS Needs Assessment Project’, *KFAS and En.v*, Kuwait City, 2019
- ❖ Research Assistant, ‘The National Youth Policy in Kuwait’ Project, *Ministry of Youth Affairs (MOYA) in partnership with Louis Berger*, Kuwait City, 2018

Department Service

- ❖ Organiser/Coordinator for IMEIS Café, Monthly Informal Peer-to-Peer Sessions, IMEIS, Durham University, Durham, October 2025 – June 2026
- ❖ Elected M.A. Representative on Staff-Student Committee, IDS, Sussex University, Brighton, 2018 – 2019

Public Speaking and Conference Presentations

Invited Webinars and Lecture

- ❖ Webinar, ‘Youth politics in MENA and beyond: Activism, political participation, and inclusive peacebuilding’, *British International Studies Association (BISA)*, 2024
- ❖ Webinar, ‘Kuwait Goes to the Polls: Discussing the 2020 Parliamentary Elections’, *LSE*, London, 2020
- ❖ Webinar, ‘Kuwait’s Election: Political and Economic Challenges’, *GIF*, Washington, D.C., 2020

- ❖ Lecture, 'Accountability and Transparency in the National Assembly', *Women's Cultural and Social Society*, Kuwait City, 2019
- ❖ Lecture, 'Who is Censoring Us?', *Hikma Society*, Kuwait City, 2017
- ❖ Lecture, 'Examining Grassroots Civil Groups in Kuwait', *Department of Political Science, George Washington University*, Washington, D.C., 2017
- ❖ Lecture, 'Challenges to Civil Society in Kuwait', *Department of English Literature, College of Arts, Kuwait University*, Kuwait City, 2017
- ❖ Lecture, 'NGO and Non-Profit as a Driver for Sustainable Development', *College of Social Science, Kuwait University*, Kuwait City, 2017

Conference Presentations

- ❖ Paper Presentation, 'Behind the Budgetary Process: The Politics of Parliamentary Committees, Procedures and the formulation of the State Budget in Kuwait', *IMEIS Annual Conference*, Durham University, Durham, 2025
- ❖ Workshop, 'The Politics of Identity in the Middle East and North Africa', *The American Political Science Association (APSA) Middle East and North Africa*, Kuwait University, Kuwait City, 2024
- ❖ Roundtable, 'Revesting the Gulf Studies: An Interdisciplinary Approach to Scope, Theory, and Data', *BISA Annual Conference*, Birmingham, 2024
- ❖ Paper Presentation, 'Kuwaiti Youth and the Evolution of the "Democratic Diwaniya"', *Middle East Studies Association (MESA) Annual Meeting*, USA, 2021
- ❖ Panel Chair/Discussant, 'Excavating Modernity in the Arab Gulf: The Case of Kuwait', *MESA Annual Meeting*, USA, 2020
- ❖ Panel Presentation, 'Politics Beyond the Political: The Case of Kuwait', *MESA Annual Meeting*, USA, 2020
- ❖ Paper Presentations, 'Civil Society and Policymaking in the Arab World Programme', *IFI—Breaking the Mold*, Beirut, 2019
- ❖ Panel Presentation, 'Unpacking the Role of Civil Society Organizations', *Nuqat's Creative Conference: The Human Capital*, Kuwait City, 2018
- ❖ Panel Presentation, 'Assessing Civic Space in the Middle East and North Africa: The Case of Kuwait', *International Centre for Non-Profit Law*, Beirut, 2017

Civic Activities

- ❖ Founder, *Raqib50* – A parliament watchdog database and application website, Kuwait City, 2013 – Present
- ❖ Lead Strategist, Constitutional Court Case – Abolition of penalties related to 'Imitation of the Opposite Sex' clause, *Penal Code Legislation, Article 193*, Kuwait City, 2020 – 2022, Verdict: Article Abolished
- ❖ Policy Advocate, Legislative Amendment – Lobbying the Kuwaiti National Assembly, formal civil societies, and the Government to amend articles related to censorship, *Press and Publication Legislation*, Kuwait City, 2016 – 2020

Fellowships and Awards

Fellowships

- ❖ Al-Sabah Programme, 'General Sir Peter de la Billière Doctoral Fellow', *Doctoral Training Programme*, SGIA, Durham University, 2022 – 2025
- ❖ Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, *The U.S.-Middle East Partnership Initiative (MEPI)*, Centre of Politics, University of Virginia, Charlottesville, 2017
- ❖ Leaders for Democracy Fellowship, MEPI, AGSI, Washington, D.C., USA, 2017

Awards

- ❖ ‘Kuwait Award for Excellence and Creativity in Digital Media’ for the work of *Raqib50, MOYA*, 2021
- ❖ ‘Franco-German Prize for Human Rights and the Rule of Law’ for the work of *Raqib50, Franco-German Council of Ministers*, 2017

**Languages
And Skills****Languages**

- ❖ Arabic (native), English (fluent), Farsi (basic)

Skills

- ❖ Nvivo, Qualtrics, R, Obsidian, Sublime Text, Microsoft Office

References

Shared upon request